

War in Yugoslavia

In 1991, Yugoslavia was torn apart by a dramatic and violent civil war, which ended with its breakup. The world witnessed some of the worst atrocities committed since World War II, NATO faced its gravest challenge concerning a sovereign nation, and Bosnia was transformed into a killing field.

BEFORE

Yugoslavia did not exist until after the end of World War I. Unification came about as Serbs called for a “land of the south Slavs.”

BIRTH OF A NATION

The Kingdom of Yugoslavia was formed out of the ashes of the **Austro-Hungarian Empire** in 1918 << 372–73. It included the formerly independent kingdoms of Serbia and Montenegro as well as the former Austro-Hungarian territories of Croatia, Slovenia, and Bosnia-Herzegovina.

JOSIP TITO'S DICTATORSHIP

Yugoslavia was invaded by Nazi Germany in World War II << 392–405. But the Germans faced **fierce resistance** from Yugoslav **communist partisans**,



JOSIP TITO

a resistance force under **Josip Tito**. Thanks to their ruthless tactics, and a flow of Russian, British, and American aid, Tito's partisans emerged at the end of the war as masters of the country.

In 1946, Tito reorganized the state into **six socialist republics**: Serbia, Croatia, Slovenia, Montenegro, Macedonia, and Bosnia-Herzegovina. There were also two semiautonomous regions within Serbia: Kosovo and Vojvodina. Until his death in 1980, Tito ruled Yugoslavia as a **one-party dictatorship**.

DISINTEGRATION OF YUGOSLAVIA

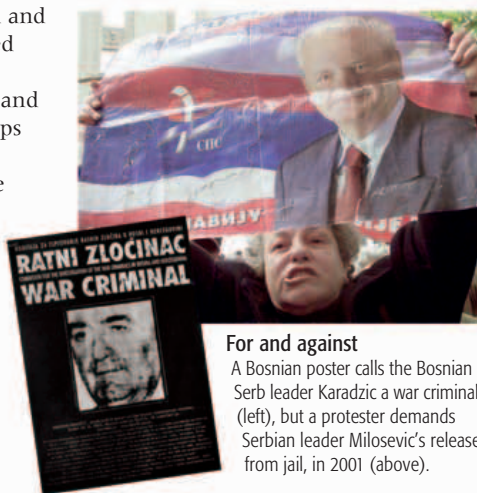
For the rest of the 1980s, Yugoslavia was ruled by a committee composed of the presidents of the six republics and two regions. The country slipped into **economic crisis**, and **national and ethnic rivalries** between the republics intensified.

By the end of the 1980s, Communism was in a state of collapse across Europe << 448–49. In 1990 the republics held multi-party elections, which further inflamed the ethnic tensions.

The collapse of communism in Europe in the 1980s encouraged the growth of nationalism in all the Yugoslav republics (see BEFORE).

In 1990, in the first multi-party elections held in Yugoslavia after the end of the communist era, both Slovenia and Croatia elected nationalist governments and national groups demanded independence throughout Yugoslavia.

In Serbia, however, Slobodan Milosevic opposed these calls. As president of the largest of the Yugoslav republics, Milosevic was determined to maintain the unity of greater Yugoslavia, with Serbia as the dominant power.



For and against

A Bosnian poster calls the Bosnian Serb leader Karadzic a war criminal (left), but a protester demands Serbian leader Milosevic's release from jail, in 2001 (above).

Initial conflicts

Serbia's political posturing soon turned into violence. In 1989, Milosevic began a crackdown on the politically assertive Albanian Muslim majority in Kosovo, a semi-independent region in southern Serbia. In 1991, when the republic of Slovenia declared its independence from Yugoslavia, the Serb-dominated Yugoslav army intervened to prevent it from seceding. The Yugoslav army was badly prepared and had to withdraw, but when the Croatian republic also claimed independence, the Yugoslav army under Milosevic launched a full-scale offensive. The city of Vukovar in eastern Croatia was destroyed, and Serbs began mass executions of Croat men. International

response was limited. The US officially recognized Slovenia and Croatia's independence, but did not intervene in the conflict. In late 1992, the United Nations (see right) brokered a ceasefire between the Serbs and the Croats.

War in Bosnia

Bosnia was the most ethnically diverse of the six Yugoslav republics, with 43 percent of the population Bosnian Muslim, 31 percent Serbian, and 17 percent Croatian. This ethnic mix proved extremely divisive: Bosnian Muslims and Croats favored independence, but Bosnian Serbs

preferred to remain a part of the wider Yugoslavia. In 1992, following a referendum that was boycotted by the Bosnian Serbs, Bosnia declared itself independent from Yugoslavia.

Milosevic's Serbian forces responded by attacking the non-Serb population of Bosnia, and Bosnian Serbs laid siege to the capital Sarajevo. Many Bosnian Muslims were imprisoned in harsh Serb-run prison camps and Muslim women raped. The international media began to use the term “ethnic cleansing” to describe the systematic expulsion and killing of ethnic and religious groups as practiced by the Serbs in Bosnia.



The siege of Sarajevo

Under siege from Bosnian Serbs, the mainly Bosnian Muslim civilians of Sarajevo struggled for survival. Water, medicine, and food were in short supply. The threat from snipers was constant and venturing into the streets perilous. A ceasefire was declared in late 1995, although the siege was not officially lifted until February 1996.

“Our time... has shown us that man's capacity for evil knows no limits.”

KOFI ANNAN, UNITED NATIONS SECRETARY GENERAL, 1997

DEMISE OF YUGOSLAVIA

From the initial calls for independence in 1991 to the peace accord in 1995, Yugoslavia was scene of many bloody battles and human rights violations.

